10 November 2025

Committee Secretary
Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters (JSCEM)
PO Box 6021
Parliament House
Canberra ACT 2600

Re: Inquiry into the 2025 federal election

Executive Summary

1. This submission is from Voices of Deakin (VoD), a volunteer-run community group that endorsed a [redacted] candidate in the 2025 Federal Election. Our volunteers' first-hand experiences at polling places in the Deakin electorate revealed a marked decline in civility and safety, and a stressful, intimidatory ordeal, rather than a respectful voting tradition.
2. Our observations, detailed in this submission, show that the current six-metre exclusion zone is demonstrably insufficient. It concentrates aggressive campaigning, creates both physical and sensory accessibility barriers for voters, and enables intimidatory behaviour that existing laws fail to address. This environment is not only a deterrent to democratic participation, but with material oversaturation at polling places, it also generates indefensible levels of environmental waste.
3. Truth in political advertising is essential to maintaining the integrity of Australia's democracy, particularly as digital campaigning and AI technologies rapidly accelerate the spread of false or misleading information. The notion that voters alone can discern truth from falsehood is flawed and it creates acceptance for deceit in political discourse, even though it is unacceptable in all other contexts. We need to prioritise transparency, accountability and truth in political communication.
4. We urge the committee to recommend practical, evidence-based reforms that restore safety, dignity, honesty and sustainability to Australian elections.

Introduction and context

5. Thank you for the opportunity to make a submission to this inquiry. VoD is a volunteer-run, community group, that was established in March 2024 as a result of the Voice Referendum outcome, and is based on the Community Independents Project (CIP) model.
6. In December 2024, VoD endorsed [redacted] as a [redacted] candidate for our electorate, at which point VoD went into hiatus, and many of our volunteers moved across to support [redacted] in her campaign. For most of us, despite our general interest in politics, this was our first time volunteering for a political campaign.
7. Firstly, VoD wishes to thank the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) for the exceptional work it does in managing the electoral process for our country, we are grateful we have such a strong, independent electoral commission.
8. VoD would also like to acknowledge that although our electoral framework has distinct areas for improvement, we are fortunate to have a strong foundation, which we are very keen to protect – compulsory voting, preferential voting, and of course the opportunity for community input through inquiries such as this, are just a few examples.
9. This submission reflects the first-hand experiences of VoD volunteers and observations of voter experiences during the 2025 Federal Election (Election), and is supported by research and policy analysis. Our observations reveal a marked decline in civility and safety at and around polling places, excessive campaign material creating congestion and waste, and a voter journey that too often resembled a stressful 'gauntlet' rather than a respectful civic ritual.

10. The Election highlighted critical gaps in Australia's electoral conduct framework. Community volunteers and voters across the Deakin electorate experienced significant levels of aggressive campaigning, safety concerns, and material oversaturation at polling places. These issues affect not only the immediate voting experience but also broader democratic engagement, voter confidence, and environmental sustainability.

11. Our observations are understood within Australia's current electoral integrity framework, particularly the *Commonwealth Electoral Act 1918* (Act), AEC policy statements on election conduct and testimonies provided at the public hearing for this inquiry on 15 October 2025 and 7 November 2025 (public hearings); they have also been considered in the context of international and domestic best practice.

12. This submission addresses:
    - aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, intimidating behaviour and safety and security
    - concerns about volunteer authenticity and transparency
    - universal voter access and inclusion
    - authorisation framework and requirements
    - donation reform
    - threats to our democracy
    - parliamentary composition as a whole
    - oversaturation and waste from campaign materials.

Current legislative framework and identified gaps

Existing protections

13. The Act currently provides two primary protections at polling places:
    - **Section 340** restricts active campaigning within six metres of a polling place entrance
    - **Section 327** prohibits interference with political liberty through violence or intimidation.

Legislative gaps

Impact on voter experience

14. The narrow buffer provided for in Section 340 of the Act, concentrates high-intensity campaigning immediately beyond the six-metre line, creating what voters and volunteers consistently describe as a 'gauntlet' effect – a zone of intense pressure, noise, and competing demands that voters must navigate to exercise their democratic right, which creates multiple problems:
    - wheelchair users, parents with strollers, and elderly voters struggle to navigate crowded entrances
    - voters face cognitive overload from overwhelming numbers of campaigners (both candidates and single-issue campaigners), and campaign materials in compressed spaces
    - voters feeling pressured, harassed, or uncomfortable
    - some voters, particularly those with disabilities or anxiety, or who are neurodiverse, may avoid in-person voting entirely.

Safety for volunteers

15. Although important, the provision of Section 327 of the Act sets a high threshold that requires proof of violent or threatening conduct. It does not adequately address the pervasive lower-level harassment and intimidatory behaviour such as aggressive verbal interactions, forceful conduct and invasion of personal space, which fall below the criminal threshold, but nonetheless create stressful and hostile voting environments.

16. Community volunteers, particularly those supporting independent or minor party candidates, reported feeling unsafe due to:
    - numerical imbalances (with both major parties deploying significantly more volunteers)
    - lack of clear conduct standards and no substantial deterrent for aggressive conduct
    - absence of protective measures or means of enforcement when harassment occurs
    - no recourse mechanism short of police intervention, which is only available in extreme cases.

International and domestic best practices

Comparative analysis

17. Our volunteers' experiences and observations of concerning behavioural conduct at the Election align with broader trends noted in **ASIO's 2025 Annual Threat Assessment**, which highlighted concerns about eroding social cohesion and increased politically motivated aggression in Australian civic spaces; this is exacerbated by Australia's current framework, which is notably weaker in comparison with similar democracies around the world.

International best practice

18. **Elections Canada** treats the entire polling place property as a neutral zone. Partisan displays, including signage and active campaigning, are prohibited on polling place premises. Campaign workers may not approach voters on the property, creating a calm, neutral environment for voting.
19. **The Electoral Commission in New Zealand** bans all campaigning on election day. During advance voting, a 10-metre restriction applies. This approach prioritises voter autonomy and reduces pressure during the voting act itself.
20. **The United Kingdom** has strict rules that prohibit campaigning within polling stations and their immediate surroundings, with clear enforcement by presiding officers.

Domestic best practice

21. **The ACT Electoral Act 1992** establishes a 100-metre no-canvassing zone around polling places. This creates meaningful spatial separation between campaign activity and voting, and helps to maintain democratic engagement. It has proven workable and enforceable over multiple election cycles, it receives strong public support, and demonstrates that expanded buffer zones do not suppress legitimate political expression.

Terms of Reference 1–2

Assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials.

Potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour.

Behavioural conduct and safety concerns

22. During the Election, the volunteers supporting various candidates were generally polite, often friendly and helped each other out when needed. However, VoD volunteers also documented numerous concerning incidents of aggression, intimidation or similar uncouth behaviour (mostly, but not always, from [redacted] Party volunteers), which as a result of the legislative gaps outlined above, could not be adequately addressed. This included:
    - verbal abuse and rough, physical behaviour directed at community volunteers
    - physical congestion and intimidating behaviour creating accessibility barriers for voters
    - volunteers promoting their candidate beyond polling place boundaries
    - aggressive, verbal confrontations directed at rival campaign workers or volunteers

- intimidating behaviour toward elderly and disabled voters.

23. Some specific examples include:
    i. Large, loud men jostling other volunteers for the best position, including on one occasion shouldering a much shorter, smaller, older female volunteer out of the way.
    ii. At one point four of the same group of loud men surrounded a group of 2–3 female voters and were shoving HTV cards at them.
    iii. A VoD volunteer found herself shirt-fronted by a tall aggressive [redacted] volunteer, making unfounded accusations that she was attacking another volunteer's religion. She reported this to the AEC team leader who advised she had had many complaints about the behaviour of this man and a couple of his associates.
    iv. Another VoD volunteer was shoved by a volunteer for the [redacted] after pointing out that they were standing in the exclusion zone. She reported this to the [redacted] who was there at the time, but he did nothing to address his volunteer's aggressive behaviour.
    v. One of our volunteers observed an elderly woman using a walker having a [redacted] volunteer leaning over her as she walked towards the entrance – the building was on her right-hand side and the [redacted] volunteer was to her left, partly excluding her view and making it impossible for anyone else to approach her. Our volunteer said it was best described as 'shepherding'.
    vi. [redacted] volunteers regularly telling voters right on the six-metre mark to "put the blue HTV card on top" of their pile.
    vii. Loud men invading personal space, with groups of 10 or more volunteers yelling the often-repeated slogan: 'Make Australia Smile Again'.
    viii. Separate from the polling place activity, another volunteer reported feeling intimidated when she encountered a "large mob of [redacted] volunteers" walking through a local group of shops.
24. On numerous occasions voters were clearly overwhelmed by the sheer number of volunteers, and a trans volunteer for our candidate reported they did not feel safe in the midst of the army of loud volunteers for the [redacted], and needed to separate themselves from the fray.
25. One final thing worth mentioning is that [redacted] volunteers were seen using screws to attach corflutes directly into lovely recycled timber fence posts at one primary school, demonstrating a total lack of respect for property that didn't belong to them. Signs were also screwed directly into trees.
26. Most incidents occurred during the two weeks of pre-poll voting at Ringwood Bowls Club, the former Croydon Community School and New Hope Church in Blackburn. On the whole, election day itself was somewhat more civilised, though occasional incidents were observed.

Summary

27. The sheer volume of volunteers supporting the [redacted], alongside their often aggressive and loud behaviour, was both concerning and at times overwhelming – not only for volunteers of non-[redacted] Party candidates, but also, even more worryingly, to the voting public.
28. The media reports of intimidation and harassment, and volume of submissions also reporting this behaviour, provide evidence that the voting experience is becoming, at least in some polling places, a trial of emotional resilience. This is not an experience that will build trust and engagement in the democratic process, and one can only wonder what first time voters in the more deeply affected polling places thought.
29. More generally, innumerable volunteers persistently thrusting paper at people whether they request it or not, demonstrates quite the level of disrespect towards Australian voters, and preaching or chanting at people queueing to vote makes the experience extremely unpleasant.

Recommendations

30. VoD supports measures that that respect voters' intelligence and capability, and which create respectful, but distinct spaces for campaigning and voting. It is requested that JSCEM considers bringing voting at the federal level in line with international and domestic best practice by:

i. Treating the entire polling place property as an exclusion zone where signage and active campaigning are prohibited.

ii. Extending the exclusion zone outside the polling place property (no less than 50 metres suggested), which would end at the requisite distance from the *property* entrance. For example, if the polling place is a school, the exclusion zone would end at the requisite distance from the gate of the school grounds, not from the door of the building where voting is taking place.
   - This has proven workable in Australian conditions and aligns with international best practices. By improving accessibility and distancing campaigning, the 'gauntlet' effect is addressed directly and voter stress is reduced, while maintaining opportunity for legitimate political expression outside the exclusion zone.

iii. Requiring AEC officials to clearly demarcate the end of the ‘exclusion zone’ the day prior to election day, and the day prior to the commencement of pre-poll voting, when there would be suitable opportunity to properly measure the distance and put up official signage or use some sort of highly visible tape on the ground so there is no confusion, may also be helpful.
   - To prevent inadvertent transgression of boundaries prior to boundaries being marked, consideration could also be given to having a set time from when campaign signage can be displayed – AEC would establish the boundary prior to this set time, and no campaign activity could commence until after that time. If the zone is properly measured and marked, AEC officials could potentially be empowered to remove signage that appears within the clearly indicated exclusion zone.

iv. Placing restrictions on the number of volunteers a candidate can have campaigning near the start of the exclusion zone at a given time, noting that any restrictions need to make allowances for polling places with multiple access points, as well as a necessary increase in volunteer numbers during shift changes and handovers.
   - For health and safety reasons, and for reasons of practicality, VoD believes that allowing three volunteers and/or campaign workers per polling place entrance would be reasonable.
   - If such restrictions are introduced, consideration needs to be given to how this could be successfully enforced.

v. Legislating a specific offence of electoral violence or intimidation that covers:
   - Aggressive verbal or rough physical conduct, invasion of personal space or persistently approaching voters, and discriminatory or any other behaviour that creates a hostile environment.
   - Property damage or threats related to electoral participation.
   - Other lower-threshold harassment that currently falls outside section 327 provisions.

vi. Charging the AEC with the development and implementation of a ‘code of conduct’ for campaign workers and volunteers, which clearly outlines behavioural expectations, prohibits aggressive approaches, blocking, following or discriminatory behaviour, chanting and preaching at voters (as opposed to respectful, reasoned engagement), and which also respects personal space and voter autonomy. This would:
   - Ideally, include a way of indicating that campaign workers and volunteers have agreed to the code of conduct – maybe the code of conduct is agreed to online and the person is emailed a pass to print off that would act as a permit of sorts for campaign activities at the end of the exclusion zone.
   - Ideally be applied to volunteers for third parties and single-issue campaigners.
   - Require provisions for removal and penalties if breaches occur.

31. VoD believes measures such as these would create meaningful separation between campaign activity and voting, which allow voters to approach polling places without having to navigate the frenetic and increasingly intimidating activity of competing campaigns, and return voting to a dignified, respectful experience.

Transparency and volunteer authenticity

32. VoD volunteers observed a large number of working-aged people who were 'volunteering' for the [redacted], for the entirety of pre-poll, giving us the impression that at least some of them may have been paid to be there and not, in fact, volunteers. In addition, the manner of dress of some volunteers, combined with behaviour that matched media reports, indicates that the Exclusive Brethren was likely well-represented in Deakin.

33. The blurring of lines between paid campaign workers and genuine community volunteers raises transparency issues. If paid campaign teams that voters cannot distinguish from genuine grassroots supporters are being deployed to give the appearance of community support, it is deceitful and should be prohibited.

Recommendation

34. Electoral observation bodies including the Organisation for Security and Co-operation in Europe (OSCE) recommend transparency in campaign operations. VoD requests that JSCEM consider a requirement for parties and candidates to have visible identification requirements for paid workers at polling places, and strengthening of AEC guidance on authentic volunteer representation, including enforcement mechanisms for misrepresentation.

Term of Reference 3

The suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements.

Accessibility gaps and concerns

35. Despite existing early voting and postal voting frameworks, significant barriers remain. One of our volunteers provided feedback that the former Croydon Community School was not suitable as a voting centre – access was difficult for the elderly and disabled, and many people had to be escorted to a suitable entrance. There were also many comments that pre-poll used to be much quieter and easier to navigate, whereas now, there are long queues and too many volunteers. In general, VoD volunteers observed the following concerns:
    - physical access issues with crowded entrances, inadequate disabled parking, and poor signage
    - sensory overload from noise, visual clutter and competing demands, overwhelming some voters
    - extra pressures for parents with children and carers accompanying elderly and disabled voters
    - distance from parking to entrance, standing in queues and navigating crowds hindering mobility and ease of access.

Recommendations

36. Ensuring universal access and inclusion in our civic duty requires AEC accessibility criteria to be met for all polling places. This should include quiet/priority voting options for voters with disabilities or sensory sensitivities, and adequate spacing and signage to support ease of navigation, with proper feedback mechanisms for voters to report accessibility barriers.

37. VoD believes that the introduction of fixed-terms would allow the AEC to secure venues well in advance based on AEC accessibility criteria, rather than at the last minute based on venue availability. This should ensure access requirements are properly met for every polling place.

38. In addition to this, or in the absence of fixed terms, VoD asks JSCEM to consider the feasibility of reserving the first few days of pre-poll for the elderly and disabled only, to ensure ease of access for them at all polling places.

Criteria for voting

39. Federal voting seems to be naturally transitioning to a model of convenience for voters. Although voters are required to meet criteria to cast their vote during pre-poll or via post, at least three of our VoD Committee members were able to vote at pre-poll without having their eligibility checked.

40. VoD believes that requiring people to meet set criteria to qualify for a pre-poll or postal vote may be outdated, and consideration could be given to allowing people a choice as to whether they vote during pre-poll, on election day or via a postal vote. We don't see any advantage to the current restrictions, and see no reason why they couldn't be lifted.

Access to voter information

41. In the current approach, policies continue to be announced and costings released well after pre-poll has commenced – often as late as a few days before election day. With the number of pre-poll voters growing (42% in 2025), it means that more and more voters are casting their votes before all pertinent information is available. Some people will not change their mind regardless of what new information comes to light; however, there are many who might.

42. VoD asks JSCEM to consider whether policy announcement and release of costings should be prohibited after pre-poll has commenced, to ensure all voters are able to make fully informed decisions about who they will vote for.

Duration of pre-poll

43. In 2025, according to the AEC, 42% cast their vote during pre-poll and 13% voted by post, which means 45% voted on election day. If a little under half of the voting population manages to cast a vote in a single day, it's hard to fathom why two weeks is needed for 42% to vote at pre-poll.

44. VoD believes that two weeks of pre-poll is unnecessary, and that it could easily be shortened to one week, particularly with fixed terms, which would allow people to plan in advance. Concerns about increased queues could be addressed by increasing the number of polling places available; that is, having more polling places for one week, rather than fewer polling places for two weeks, which would also mean volunteers are spread across more locations, not all converging on two or three locations.

Term of Reference 4

The suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.

Authorisation requirements and gaps

45. Section 321D of the Act requires that all electoral communications be authorised so that voters can identify who is seeking to influence them. The AEC's 2025 guidance clarifies how authorisations should be displayed across traditional and digital media, including online content, podcasts, and influencer channels.

46. VoD strongly supports this requirement and the AEC's website has been well set up to assist in determining what is required. Despite this, we believe it could be streamlined, as making sure the various communication types are authorised in the correct way is confusing.

47. In addition, the Election highlighted practical limitations and a regulatory 'grey zone' in the framework relating to influencer/creator content, AI-assisted content, and emergent micro-targeted ads.

Recommendations

Authorisation requirements

48. With respect to streamlining the content of authorisations, VoD asks JSCEM to consider whether:

i. Having variations on address information is necessary – could there be a blanket requirement for either the relevant town/city to be on everything, *or* a blanket requirement for the full address to be on everything, regardless of who is authorising or the communication type?

ii. It is feasible to have a website (where available) as a preferred alternative to address information, as this would allow people to find out more about the authorising entity – if people are unfamiliar with the name, an address is not going to provide any clarity for them.

Personal safety concerns for community volunteers

49. If full address is to remain a requirement, VoD would also ask JSCEM to consider options for entities that do not have an address. For example, as a small, community volunteer group, VoD does not have an address, which meant that a member of the Steering Committee had to include their personal address on authorisations on our website and social media – we found it deeply concerning that the home address of one of our members was publicly available, particularly in the context of increased aggression in the political arena generally.

Regulatory gaps

50. To address the regulatory gaps, VoD suggests JSCEM consider an amendment section 321D that:
    - explicitly covers both paid and in-kind influencer activity
    - explicitly covers all AI-generated or AI-edited electoral material, including a requirement for a human-readable authorisation that complies with the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2 (applied to print and online materials), and a provenance or content-credentials tag verifying human involvement.

51. Combined with platform co-operation to manage unauthorised content, these measures would modernise the authorisation framework, improve transparency, and future-proof it against emerging communication technologies.

Term of Reference 5

The implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election.

Donation reform

52. VoD understands the stated intent behind these reforms is to improve transparency, reduce undue influence, and restore public trust. However, we are deeply concerned about the way they were introduced, the disproportionate impact they have on independents and community-based campaigns, and the advantage that they will give major parties. VoD also notes that feedback provided throughout the public hearings frequently expressed the same concerns.

53. Electoral reform of this magnitude should be developed through a transparent and consultative process over time; however, this legislation was introduced and passed with remarkable haste. Rushed law-making risks undermining confidence in the very democratic system that the reforms were meant to protect.

54. Under the new rules, donation caps are applied per registered party. However, what most Australians see as one political party – such as [redacted] or the [redacted] – is actually made up of multiple registered state and territory divisions. Each of those entities can receive donations up to the full cap, multiplying their total fundraising capacity.

55. By contrast, a community independent campaign can receive donations only up to a single cap. This creates a clear inequity: the established parties face far fewer practical constraints on fundraising than independents or new entrants. The effect is to entrench the dominance of major parties and to make it significantly harder for local, community-driven campaigns to participate on equal terms.

56. The reforms provide a significant increase in public funding to established political parties and incumbent MPs, intended to offset their reduced ability to raise private donations. Independent candidates and community campaigns, however, receive no equivalent compensation.

57. In practice, this means that the major parties are both protected by public funds and relatively free to continue fundraising across multiple divisions, while new or independent candidates face tighter caps and no additional support. This imbalance weakens competition and discourages genuine community representation in Parliament.

58. While the introduction of expenditure caps was meant to level the playing field, the reality is that independents and community candidates begin from a very different position. Major parties have permanent infrastructure, staffing, and brand recognition. A newly formed local campaign, by contrast, must build everything from scratch. Equal caps across unequal structures amplify these disadvantages rather than correct them.

Recommendation

59. VoD believes that as currently designed, these reforms will have the opposite effect of their stated goals. By constraining independents and community movements, while protecting the financial advantages of major parties, the reforms risk narrowing political competition and undermining democratic representation.

60. VoD urges JSCEM to recommend postponing the implementation of these reforms on 1 July 2026, and enable a thorough review of the donation and expenditure caps to ensure parity between independents, new parties, and established political organisations, and a more equitable approach to public funding that recognises and supports, rather than discourages everyday Australians who wish to participate in grass-roots community politics at the federal level.

Term of Reference 6

Reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic.

Truth in political advertising

61. Truth in political advertising is fundamental to safeguarding Australia's democratic process. In an era of rapid information dissemination and digital campaigning, the spread of false or misleading political content, whether deliberate or inadvertent, poses a significant threat to the integrity of our elections. Both foreign and domestic actors can exploit gaps in current regulation to distort public debate and undermine informed voter choice.

62. It has been commented a number of times in response to this issue that voters will determine whether information is true or not. This concept is fundamentally flawed. It completely overlooks the basic premise that lying is unacceptable and those who deliberately set out to deceive should be held accountable – it actually encourages the dishonest behaviour we need to curb. Voters have enough to deal with in life. They should not have to (or be expected to) waste their precious time policing whether or not a political statement, video or image is intended to manipulate them or inform them.

63. The rapid advancement of AI, particularly technologies capable of producing realistic 'deepfake' audio, video, and imagery, presents a new and urgent dimension to the challenge of truth in political advertising. These tools can be used to fabricate convincing representations of political figures or events – something that will erode public confidence in legitimate information and amplify opportunities for electoral interference.

64. The Australian Communications and Media Authority's (ACMA's) fourth disinformation report to government (August 2025), notes that most Australians believe political deepfakes are rising, **but do not feel confident in detecting them**. Without clear standards of authenticity, disclosure, and accountability, AI-generated disinformation risks distorting voter perceptions on a scale and with a speed previously unimaginable.

65. A healthy democracy values and depends on freedom of expression, and must protect the right to strong, honest opinion and open commentary. However, it also depends on the integrity of information circulating in the public sphere. Deliberate falsehoods and disinformation are not freedom of expression; when speech is used to deceive or distort, and undermine informed decision-making, it becomes manipulation, not dialogue.

Recommendations

66. To strengthen public trust and protect against interference, Australia must adopt reforms that promote transparency, accountability, and truthfulness in political communication, ensuring that electoral outcomes reflect genuine democratic will rather than manipulation, disinformation or fear.

67. VoD believes a practical recommendation could be to adopt a federal truth in political advertising standard, modelled on South Australia's long-standing model (Electoral Act 1985 (SA), s 113), which makes it an offence to authorise material that is 'inaccurate and misleading to a material extent", and explicitly extend it to AI-generated or materially AI-manipulated content. This could include:
    - a positive duty to label AI-generated/AI-manipulated political material, with clear and legible authorisations that meet web content accessibility guidelines (WCAG)
    - a fast-track power for the AEC to order withdrawal/correction during the regulated election period
    - alignment with emerging content-credibility standards, so legitimate campaign material isn't mistakenly removed.

68. If the South Australian model is not considered workable in the federal context, then VoD recommends a dedicated inquiry into truth in political advertising laws, with representation extending beyond JSCEM to reflect the issue's democratic significance.

69. VoD envisages that such an inquiry would include parliamentarians across the spectrum, supported by experts in constitutional and electoral law, and draw on the experience of the AEC and the Electoral Commission of South Australia – and potentially consulting with all electoral commissions could be helpful. Given the dominance of online campaigning, input from ACMA and major digital platforms is essential, and civil society organisations should contribute public perspectives.

70. Regardless of the approach, it is imperative that federal electoral law prohibit political advertising that is demonstrably false, with an express requirement to clearly label AI-generated or AI-manipulated material.

Term of Reference 7

The composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.

Length of parliamentary term

71. VoD supports a shift from three-year terms to four-terms. Although it means voters engage in our democracy less frequently, it would provide greater opportunity for policy and programs to be implemented and have a chance of achieving the intended outcome for the people, and the country would not spend one out of the three years in election mode – be it speculation about the date or active campaigning.

72. Accordingly, VoD supports a shift to eight-year terms for Senators. While this is a long term, the current Senate composition of having terms being set at double the length of MPs is designed to provide stability and continuity in its role of reviewing legislation, while at the same time maintaining somewhat of a separation from the ebb and flow of electoral pressures.

73. Having a different balance of power in the Senate to the House of Representatives is a critical check and balance for our democracy – a Senate that is not entirely at the whim of the contemporary political pressures of the day is an important part of achieving this check and balance.

Fixed terms

74. VoD strongly supports a shift to fixed-terms, preferably through constitutional change. Election timing should be about the people's opportunity to hold a government to account based on a full term of governing, not on what is to a government's best advantage for re-election.

75. In VoD's opinion, and as observed on more than one occasion during the public hearings, one of the critical benefits of a fixed-term is that it would allow the AEC to plan and secure polling place venues well in advance, ensuring that polling places would meet strict accessibility criteria.
    i. As noted during the AEC's testimony at the public hearing, with election dates being kept a secret as they currently are, it means that once the date is finally known, the AEC has just 33 days to sign approximately 7,000 leases – and even less time for the pre-poll venues. It's madness to consider this an acceptable level of logistical pressure to place on the AEC when it could otherwise focus on more important aspects of ensuring a successful election.
    ii. The current level of secrecy around when elections will be held means that venues are secured not based on whether they meet the necessary criteria, but on what is available a month out from the election date once it has been called. This is a system that is not fit-for-purpose.
76. VoD acknowledges that by its very nature, a double dissolution election could not operate on this basis and there will sometimes be an exception to the rule. However, double dissolutions are rare, only seven in 125 years – this is not a reason to not run general federal elections on a set timetable.
77. VoD would also ask JSCEM to consider whether provisions in the Australian Constitution that allow for the Prime Minister to advise the Governor-General to dissolve Parliament, as highlighted by Professor Anne Twomey in her public hearing testimony, require amendment in the context of changing to fixed terms.
78. Finally, all but one of the state and territory governments in Australia have fixed terms; it would seem sensible to have voting across Australia as consistent as possible.

Number of elected representatives

79. VoD supports exploring a change to the number of elected representatives to ensure that representation keeps pace with population growth, electoral boundaries remain manageable, constituent-representative ratios remain effective and regional and community representation is maintained.
80. Significant population growth since the last increase in the number of parliamentarians, mean it is harder for Australians to interact with their local member, and regional and rural electorates are becoming increasingly unmanageable in size.
81. An increase to the number of parliamentarians would mean fewer people vying for their MP's attention, making it easier for Australians to be heard, and less travel means MPs would have more time to attend to other more important tasks.

Achieving change

82. Four-year terms would require a referendum. However, despite the Prime Minister's personal support for the concept, VoD notes there have been media reports of the government ruling out any further referendums during the current Prime Minister's tenure, citing past failures.
83. It would be disappointing if such a simple improvement to our democracy could not be made, simply because we thought it was too difficult to achieve a successful outcome. With genuine non-partisan support it can be achieved, and VoD urges JSCEM to recommend the reform, as the benefits to Australia's democracy are too important to be dismissed without trying.
84. Should a referendum be held, VoD suggests a ballot with two questions, one about moving to fixed terms, and the other about moving to four-year terms. It would be a shame for change to not be implemented simply because voting 'no' to one aspect meant voting 'no' to both, even if they didn't object to both.

Recommendations outside of the Terms of Reference

Environmental impact and material waste

85. Although this issue is not specifically covered in the Terms of Reference, VoD believes it is an aspect of elections that is now well out of hand and needs to be addressed as a priority. VoD notes that a number of people providing testimony at the public hearing have also expressed concerns about it, including the AEC, and some submissions have also touched on it.

86. At all polling places, VoD volunteers witnessed an endless sea of corflutes and plastic signage wrap, and what seemed to be virtual forests of HTV information. The concentration of material distribution at polling place entrances exacerbated congestion and generated waste that voters often discarded within meters of receiving it, including:
    - millions of printed how-to-vote cards (many unread, and frequently discarded in landfill)
    - thousands of petroleum-based plastic corflute signs (most likely not recycled)
    - plastic wrapping, cable ties, stakes
    - transportation and storage impacts.

87. The waste in Deakin alone was excessive, but when you multiply that by every other electorate in the country, the scale of the problem is horrifying and totally unjustifiable.

Recommendations

88. The amount of waste generated by our federal elections needs to be curbed significantly. VoD requests that JSCEM consider the following options for achieving this.

Corflutes, plastic wrap and signage

89. VoD believes there is scope for significantly reducing signage and strongly supports:
    - banning the use of plastic wrap entirely
    - setting maximum limits on signage
    - banning corflutes and signage anywhere within the exclusion zone
    - implementing a mandatory national corflute recycling scheme[1], or introducing a means for holding candidates accountable for the waste they produce
    - requiring biodegradable or recyclable materials for all campaign items.

HTV cards

90. There are a number of restrictions that could be placed on printed HTV cards. VoD strongly supports:
    - restricting the number of printed HTV cards allowed at a polling place
    - prohibiting volunteers from distributing HTV cards within the exclusion zone
    - providing unstaffed, neutral information tables at the entrance of or just inside the polling place, where HTV cards are available *should voters wish to take one* – noting that logistics around ensuring adequate supply is maintained would need to be addressed
    - providing an easy access, clearly signed, centralised return point for HTV cards as voters exit the polling place, which could then be returned to (or collected by) volunteers for re-use
    - signage near rubbish bins asking people not to dispose of HTV cards in recycling, not landfill
    - introducing digital alternatives for HTV information.

[1] The ACT Corflute Collection Trial (2021) demonstrated the viability of centralised recycling schemes. The trial collected and recycled campaign signage post-election, reducing landfill waste significantly. It proved to be logistically feasible with industry partnership and has created a model for national implementation.

91. VoD believes that implementing digital alternatives to printed HTV cards holds the most promise for making a substantial difference. QR codes, hosting of how-to-vote materials on the AEC website, and mobile apps all offer pathways to notable reduction of physical waste, while maintaining voter information access.

92. Our candidate trialled the use of QR codes on signage at polling places for foreign language HTV information. This was implemented quite late in the piece and due to limited funds, we had no ability to track how extensively (or if) this was utilised. However, for the next federal election, VoD will likely recommend to our endorsed candidate that use of QR codes be considered as a key source of HTV information to reduce waste and cost.

Key Recommendations

Behavioural conduct, and safety at polling places (ToR 1, 2)

- Replace the six-metre rule with a campaign-free exclusion zone of at least 50 metres from the polling place property entrance, with the AEC to clearly mark the start of the exclusion zones before voting begins.
- Create a legislated offence of 'electoral violence or intimidation', covering aggressive, discriminatory or obstructive behaviour.
- Require the AEC to establish and a Code of Conduct for campaigners and volunteers with permit-style identification (extending to third party and single-issue volunteers if possible).
- Limit the volunteers allowed per polling-place (with flexibility for shift changes and multiple entry points); and mandate visible identification for paid campaign workers.

Universal voter access (ToR 3)

- Adopt fixed-term elections to secure venues early and improve accessibility and voter experience.
- Shorten the length of pre-poll voting to one week, with more polling places available – greater dispersal of volunteers will help reduce both congestion and intimidatory or aggressive conduct.
- Consider reserving the first days of pre-poll for elderly and disabled voters.
- Prohibit the announcement of new policies or costings after pre-poll has commenced, ensuring all voters can make a fully informed decision.

Authorisation framework (ToR 4)

- Standardise address requirements for authorisations, and consider allowing a web address instead of a street address so that voters can find out more about the entity authorising the communication.
- Urgently address the inherent safety concerns for small, volunteer-run community groups who need to provide a personal address because the entity does not have a fixed premises.
- Extend section 321D of the Act to cover paid and in-kind influencer content and require clear, legible authorisations for AI-generated and AI-edited political material.

Donation reforms (ToR 5)

- Postpone implementation of the donation and expenditure cap reforms due on 1 July 2026 to enable a thorough review that will ensure parity between independents and the multi-entity structures of established parties, and an equitable framework that does not restrict or disadvantage genuine community participation.

Threats of interference (ToR 6)

- Introduce a federal truth in political advertising law that prohibits materially false electoral content, modelled on South Australia's law, or establish a dedicated inquiry into truth in political advertising, with membership beyond parliamentarians and which reflects the issue's democratic significance.
- Require that AI-generated or AI-manipulated material is clearly and legibly labelled as such.

Parliamentary composition (ToR 7)

- Introduce fixed terms to enable the AEC to plan and secure fully accessible polling venues well in advance, instead of scrambling for last-minute, often unsuitable, locations.
- Consider:
  - introducing four-year terms for the House of Representatives, provided half-Senate elections are maintained
  - increasing the number of parliamentarians to regain equitable representation that has been lost due to population growth.

Environmental impact of elections (outside of ToR)

- Ban plastic wrap entirely; restrict the amount of signage allowed; mandate recyclable or biodegradable campaign materials; and implement a national corflute-recycling scheme.
- Restrict printed HTV cards, by driving implementation of digital alternatives (e.g., QR codes or apps).

Conclusion

93. Voters, volunteers and workers must be able to participate in elections without fear of harassment, intimidation, or abuse. Electoral processes must be inclusive and navigable for all citizens regardless of age, disability, or circumstances; they should also minimise environmental harm and model sustainable practices.

94. Electoral integrity depends on public trust in fair, orderly, well-administered processes – campaign operations should be open, honest, and clearly distinguishable, and the act of voting should be conducted in an environment of mutual respect and civic dignity.

95. The Election revealed that Australia's current electoral conduct framework no longer serves voters, volunteers, or democratic integrity adequately. The six-metre buffer is demonstrably insufficient, conduct standards are unclear, provisions for addressing aggressive or intimidatory behaviour are inadequate, and material waste is environmentally indefensible.

96. There are solutions that are proven, practical, and precedented. The ACT has successfully operated a 100-metre zone for years. Canada and New Zealand demonstrate that stronger protections enhance rather than diminish democratic participation, and the ACT corflute trial shows that waste reduction is achievable.

97. Finally, mandating truth in political advertising is urgently required to preserve public confidence in our democratic process. The ACMA's 2025 disinformation report finding that most Australians believe political deepfakes are rising, but few feel confident in identifying such content, is gravely concerning. Upholding truth in political communication is not about restricting freedom of expression; it is about safeguarding the right of every voter to participate in a democracy built on fact, fairness, and respect, and freedom from manipulation.

98. We urge JSCEM to recommend these evidence-based reforms to restore voting to what it should be: a safe, respectful, accessible civic ritual that honours, rather than tests democratic participation.